WEEK 2 · LECTURE L1 · UNIT II

Kahn's Three Conditions of Engagement

The original theory of personal engagement, the evidence that tested it, and how it differs from rival accounts of what engagement is.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Explain Kahn's definition of personal engagement and disengagement.
- Diagnose a workplace using the three psychological conditions and their antecedents.
- Distinguish engagement from satisfaction, commitment, workaholism and burnout.
- Compare Kahn's account with the UWES and Gallup Q12 views of engagement.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 2 (apply validated engagement models) and CLO 3 (evaluate motivation theories).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

The employee who works the longest hours in the team is the most engaged.

True or false? Name one thing that hours cannot tell you.

THE ORIGINAL STUDY · KAHN (1990)

Engagement as bringing the self to the role

METHOD

Ethnographic study of summer camp counselors and members of an architecture firm, observed moment by moment.

ENGAGEMENT

Harnessing the self to the work role: physically, cognitively and emotionally.

DISENGAGEMENT

Withdrawing and defending the self: performing the role while personally absent.

KEY POINT

Engagement varies from moment to moment and task to task, not only from person to person.

THE THREE PSYCHOLOGICAL CONDITIONS

Each condition answers a question the person asks

Condition	The person's question	What shapes it
Meaningfulness	Is it worth bringing myself into this?	Task characteristics, role characteristics, work interactions
Safety	Can I show myself without fear of consequences?	Relationships, group dynamics, management style, norms
Availability	Do I have the energy to bring myself now?	Physical and emotional energy, insecurity, life outside work

EXAM LENS

A low score on one condition needs its own remedy. Better pay does not repair safety; a kinder boss does not repair exhaustion.

Kahn (1990)

FROM CONDITIONS TO PERFORMANCE

The chain the evidence supports

ANTECEDENTS

Job enrichment and role fit; supportive supervisors and rewarding coworkers; available resources

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CONDITIONS

Meaningfulness, safety and availability

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ENGAGEMENT

Physical, cognitive and emotional investment in the role

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OUTCOMES

Task performance and organizational citizenship behavior

Antecedents to engagement: May, Gilson and Harter (2004). Engagement to outcomes: Rich, LePine and Crawford (2010).

ENGAGEMENT AND ITS NEIGHBORS

Constructs that are often confused

Construct	What it is	Why it differs from engagement
Satisfaction	Contentment with the job	Satiation, not energy
Commitment	Attachment to the organization	Its target is the firm, not the work
Workaholism	Compulsive, excessive working	Driven by inner pressure, not presence
Burnout	Exhaustion and cynicism	The erosion of engagement

Macey and Schneider (2008); Schaufeli, Taris and van Rhenen (2008)

TELLING THEORIES APART

The employee who works the longest hours

Lens	What it asks	Possible reading
Kahn	Is the self present in the role?	Truly present, or performing presence
Workaholism	Is the drive compulsive?	Hours reflect pressure, not energy
Burnout	Is energy being depleted?	Long hours now, exit later

EXAM LENS

Hours are a behavior; engagement is a psychological state. Name the state before you judge the behavior.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KAHN (1990)

Three conditions decide what people bring to work

THE CORE IDEA

People decide, moment by moment, how much of themselves to invest in a role.

HOW IT WORKS

They invest when the work feels worth it, when showing the self is not risky, and when they have energy to give.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Built from 32 people in two settings; a qualitative theory with no measure of its own.

IN PRACTICE

In a call center where agents read fixed scripts and errors are named in public, low meaningfulness and low safety can sit beside perfect attendance.

EXAM LENS

Diagnose a case condition by condition. Its weakness is measurement, so pair it with May et al. or Rich et al. for evidence.

THEORY IN DEPTH · MAY, GILSON AND HARTER (2004)

The first quantitative test of Kahn's theory

THE CORE IDEA

All three conditions were positively related to engagement in a field survey of employees.

HOW IT WORKS

Meaningfulness had the strongest link. Job enrichment and role fit built it; supportive supervisors built safety.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

One organization, one point in time, self reports: links are associations, not proven causes.

IN PRACTICE

A firm that enriches jobs but keeps a punitive supervisor raises meaningfulness while safety stays low, so engagement stalls.

EXAM LENS

Cite it to show Kahn's theory has evidence, and to argue that meaningfulness deserves first priority.

THEORY IN DEPTH · RICH, LEPINE AND CRAWFORD (2010)

Why engagement matters for performance

THE CORE IDEA

Engagement is the investment of physical, cognitive and emotional energy in the role, built on Kahn.

HOW IT WORKS

Engagement linked value congruence, organizational support and core self evaluations to task performance and citizenship.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

The sample was firefighters; extending the findings to other jobs needs care.

IN PRACTICE

An HR team that runs only a satisfaction survey misses the state that best predicted performance.

EXAM LENS

Use it to show engagement predicts performance beyond job satisfaction, job involvement and intrinsic motivation.

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Three ways of defining engagement

	Kahn (1990)	UWES (Schaufeli et al., 2002)	Gallup Q12 (Harter et al., 2002)
What it is	Bringing the self into the role	Vigor, dedication and absorption	Conditions employees report, in 12 items
Level	Person, moment to moment	Person, fairly stable state	Business unit
Drivers	Meaningfulness, safety, availability	Job and personal resources	Clear expectations through to growth
Weakness	No measure of its own	Says little about how safety is built	Measures conditions more than engagement

EXAM LENS

They complement each other: Kahn explains why, the UWES measures the state, Q12 tracks conditions a manager can act on.

APPLY IT · ILLUSTRATIVE CASES

Usually one condition fails first

A BANK BRANCH

Errors are rebuked in front of customers. Safety fails, so staff stop reporting problems.

A BPO FLOOR

Agents read fixed scripts on repetitive calls. Meaningfulness fails even with good pay.

A COMPONENTS PLANT

Rotating night shifts and long commutes drain energy. Availability fails.

EXAM TIP

These are illustrations for analysis, not real firms. In an answer, name the condition, the evidence you would look for and the fix.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Kahn's three conditions explain engagement better than the Job Demands Resources model." Critically evaluate. **20 marks**

A strong answer: defines both; compares mechanism, level and measurement; uses May et al. and Bakker and Demerouti; takes a reasoned position.

An Indian bank reports high attendance but falling service scores. Diagnose the causes with Kahn's framework and recommend remedies. **20 marks**

A strong answer: separates attendance from engagement; tests each condition with evidence; links antecedents from May et al.; prioritizes and notes limits.

Distinguish work engagement from job satisfaction and workaholism. **10 marks**

A strong answer: precise definitions; energy versus contentment; presence versus compulsion; cites Schaufeli, Taris and van Rhenen.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. Engagement is presence in the role, not long hours or contentment
2. Meaningfulness, safety and availability fail for different reasons and need different fixes
3. Kahn explains, the UWES measures, Q12 tracks conditions: use each for its own job

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

Kahn, W. A. (1990). Psychological conditions of personal engagement and disengagement at work. *Academy of Management Journal, 33*(4), 692–724. (Lesson Plan: Sections I to III.)

Bhatnagar, J. (2007). Talent management strategy of employee engagement in Indian ITES employees: Key to retention. *Employee Relations, 29*(6), 640–663.

Bakker, A. B., & Demerouti, E. (2017). Job demands–resources theory: Taking stock and looking forward. *Journal of Occupational Health Psychology, 22*(3), 273–285.

HOW TO USE THESE

These are the Week 2 set readings. Kahn (1990) is the core reading for this lecture; Bakker and Demerouti (2017) is the core reading for Lecture 3.

Sources for this lecture (1 of 3)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Bakker, A. B., & Demerouti, E. (2017). Job demands–resources theory: Taking stock and looking forward. *Journal of Occupational Health Psychology, 22*(3), 273–285. https://doi.org/10.1037/ocp0000056

Harter, J. K., Schmidt, F. L., & Hayes, T. L. (2002). Business unit level relationship between employee satisfaction, employee engagement, and business outcomes: A meta analysis. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 87*(2), 268–279. https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.87.2.268

Kahn, W. A. (1990). Psychological conditions of personal engagement and disengagement at work. *Academy of Management Journal, 33*(4), 692–724. https://doi.org/10.2307/256287

Sources for this lecture (2 of 3)

Macey, W. H., & Schneider, B. (2008). The meaning of employee engagement. *Industrial and Organizational Psychology, 1*(1), 3–30. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1754-9434.2007.0002.x

May, D. R., Gilson, R. L., & Harter, L. M. (2004). The psychological conditions of meaningfulness, safety and availability and the engagement of the human spirit at work. *Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 77*(1), 11–37. https://doi.org/10.1348/096317904322915892

Rich, B. L., LePine, J. A., & Crawford, E. R. (2010). Job engagement: Antecedents and effects on job performance. *Academy of Management Journal, 53*(3), 617–635. https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2010.51468988

Sources for this lecture (3 of 3)

Schaufeli, W. B., Salanova, M., González-Romá, V., & Bakker, A. B. (2002). The measurement of engagement and burnout: A two sample confirmatory factor analytic approach. *Journal of Happiness Studies, 3*(1), 71–92. https://doi.org/10.1023/a:1015630930326

Schaufeli, W. B., Taris, T. W., & van Rhenen, W. (2008). Workaholism, burnout, and work engagement: Three of a kind or three different kinds of employee well being? *Applied Psychology, 57*(2), 173–203. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1464-0597.2007.00285.x